

DistroForge

User Guide · 0.17 Alpha

Build your own Debian-based Linux distribution as a live ISO, step by step.

DistroForge
0.17 Alpha - ISO builder for Debian-based distributions

1. Start

Quick Wizard

2. Repositories

3. Identity & Branding

4. Users

5. Language

6. Desktop

7. Software

8. Kernel & Boot

9. Look & Feel

10. System Sounds

11. Welcome Screen

12. Installer

13. Advanced

14. Review & Apply

15. Check & Build

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Support DistroForge

Dark mode

My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64

Step 14 of 15 - Review & Apply — 15 done **Review & Apply: 5 waiting**

Review & Apply

Step 14 - Everything you chose waits here. Tick each change when you are sure, or go back and change it. Then apply them all at once.

Changes waiting to be applied

☒ 1. Install the Xfce desktop (full with applications) — Desktop

☒ 2. Install 3 package(s) — Software

☐ 3. Apply the system sound theme — System Sounds

☐ 4. Install the welcome screen — Welcome Screen

☐ 5. Apply the GRUB theme — Kernel & Boot

2 of 5 change(s) checked — tick every change you are sure about to apply them

Tick all

Go back and change it

Remove from the list

Up

Down

Apply all changes

Changes run in this order. A failed change stops the rest; nothing is lost.

Your distribution so far

Name: My Linux 1.0

◀ Back: 13. Advanced

✓ done **Done — next step: 15. Check & Build ▶**

✓ List Flatpak apps finished

Waiting in Review & Apply: Install the Xfce desktop (full with applications)

Waiting in Review & Apply: Install 3 package(s)

Waiting in Review & Apply: Apply the system sound theme

Waiting in Review & Apply: Install the welcome screen

Waiting in Review & Apply: Apply the GRUB theme

Added to Review & Apply: Apply the GRUB theme (5 waiting)

Hide log

Hugo Moniz do Rego · GPL-3.0-or-later · <https://github.com/hugomonizdorego/Eduka-Customizer>

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1. What is DistroForge?

DistroForge is free and open source software (GPL-3.0-or-later) to build your own Linux distribution from Debian or a Debian derivative. The result is a live ISO that boots from a USB stick or DVD (BIOS and UEFI) and installs with the Calamares installer.

You can start from:

- a live ISO of Debian or a Debian derivative (for example LMDE, MX Linux, antiX, Kali Linux, Parrot OS, Deepin, SparkyLinux, BunsenLabs, Q4OS)
- a new Debian base system (stable, testing or sid) made with mmdebstrap/debootstrap
- a copy of this computer (snapshot)

Ubuntu-based ISOs (Ubuntu, Linux Mint's Ubuntu edition, Pop!_OS, elementary OS, Zorin OS) are not supported: DistroForge is made for Debian-based distributions. DistroForge itself installs on Debian, Debian derivatives and Ubuntu.

The work is split into 15 steps. The next step opens when the one before is done, so you always know what comes next. Experts can open every step in Settings.

2. Installing and starting

Install the .deb package (it pulls in every tool it needs):

```
sudo apt install ./distroforge_0.17.0~alpha_all.deb
```

Start it from the application menu (**DistroForge**) or a terminal:

```
distroforge          # the window (asks for the admin password)
sudo distroforge --help # command line
```

The old command `eduka-customizer` still works and opens DistroForge. Old settings in `/etc/eduka-customizer` are read automatically.

Needs: Debian 12 or newer (or a derivative), 4 GB RAM, free disk space of three times the ISO size.

3. Step 1 · Start: create a project

Choose where your distribution comes from: open an ISO, download an official Debian live ISO, bootstrap a new Debian base, or copy this computer. Each project is one folder with the system, the settings and the built ISO.

Purpose asks what the distribution is for (home, office, school, gaming, server, ...) and the ISO edition (minimal, standard, full). Use or ignore its recommendations.

The screenshot shows the DistroForge application interface. On the left is a dark sidebar with a menu: 1. Start (highlighted), Quick Wizard, 2. Repositories, 3. Identity & Branding, 4. Users, 5. Language, 6. Desktop, 7. Software, 8. Kernel & Boot, 9. Look & Feel, 10. System Sounds, 11. Welcome Screen, 12. Installer, 13. Advanced, 14. Review & Apply, 15. Check & Build, Settings, and About. Below the menu are buttons for 'Support DistroForge' and 'Dark mode'. The main area is titled 'Start' and shows 'My Linux' project at '/home/distroforge/mylinux' with 'Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64' architecture. A progress bar at the top right indicates 'Step 1 of 15 · Start — 15 done'. The 'Start' section explains the goal: 'Step 1 - Create a project and choose where your distribution starts from: a Debian live ISO (the small 'standard' ISO is recommended), another Debian-based ISO, a new Debian base, or this computer.' It offers two options: 'New project' (with fields for Name and Folder, and a 'Create project' button) and 'Open project' (with a list of existing projects and 'Open selected'/'Browse...' buttons). Below this is the 'Source of the image' section, which allows choosing the root filesystem source (Default language, Keep the language of the source, Install translations) and selecting a source (Debian / Debian-based ISO, Download Debian, New Debian base, This computer). A 'Done — next step: 2. Repositories' button is at the bottom right. A terminal log at the bottom shows 'Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux', 'Check the image', and 'Check the image finished'.

Step 1: create or open a project

The **Quick Wizard** asks everything important on 8 pages and prepares it all at once.

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Quick Wizard — 15 of 15 steps done

Quick Wizard

The fast way: answer a few questions on one page after the other, then press Finish. Every step can be fine-tuned afterwards.

Back

1. Source

2. Identity

3. Base system

4. Desktop

5. Look

6. Applications

7. Branding

8. Finish

Where does the system come from?

Project folder: /home/distroforge/mylinux

Source: Keep the system of the open project

ISO file:

Architecture (new base): amd64

Open project: /home/distroforge/mylinux (Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64)
Recommended source: the Debian live **standard** ISO (no desktop, minimal). Any Debian live ISO or a Debian derivative such as LMDE works too.

What is your distribution for?

Fills the next steps with recommendations (desktop, login screen, look, applications). Change anything you like afterwards, or choose 'Other' to decide everything yourself.

Other / my own — No recommendations: build everything yourself, page by page.

ISO edition

Full with recommended apps — Full, plus the desktop's recommended applications and the Flatpak apps (largest ISO). Recommended.

► Check the image
✓ Check the image finished
Branding package source written to /home/distroforge/mylinux/branding/mylinux-branding (8 diversions)
Copying 114 files of base-files
► List Flatpak apps
✓ List Flatpak apps finished

List Flatpak apps — finished

Hide log

Quick Wizard

4. Step 2 · Repositories

Choose the Debian version (stable, testing, sid) and mirror, enable contrib/non-free-firmware or add other repositories. Packages and updates come from here.

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Step 2 of 15 · Repositories — 15 done

Repositories

Step 2 · Where packages come from: the Debian release (stable, testing or sid) and extra repositories.

Debian suite
Writes a clean deb822 file /etc/apt/sources.list.d/debian.sources. Old Debian entries are kept as *.eduka-old.

Suite: Stable

Mirror: http://deb.debian.org/debian

Components: main contrib non-free non-free-firmware

☒ Use codename (trixie) instead of alias (stable) - avoids surprise major upgrades

☒ Security updates ☒ Stable updates ☐ Backports (stable only) ☐ Source packages (deb-src)

Preview

Apply and update

Switching an image to a newer suite needs 'Upgrade all' on the Packages page.

Source files

sources.list

debian.sources

Types: deb

URIs: http://deb.debian.org/debian

Suites: trixie trixie-updates

Components: main contrib non-free non-free-firmware

Signed-By: /usr/share/keyrings/debian-archive-keyring.gpg

Types: deb

URIs: http://security.debian.org/debian-security

Back: 1. Start

done Done — next step: 3. Identity & Branding

Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux

▶ Check the image

✓ Check the image finished

Branding package source written to /home/distroforge/mylinux/branding/mylinux-branding (8 diversions)

Copying 114 files of base-files

Ready

Hide log

APT repositories

5. Step 3 · Identity & Branding

Give your distribution a name, version, code name, web site, logo and wallpaper. The values start from what the ISO has. DistroForge builds a branding package that replaces os-release, lsb-release, issue, logos, the GRUB menu and the installer branding.

Important: use a name and logo of your own. Names such as 'Debian ...' or 'Ubuntu ...' are trademarks; the check before building warns when the name uses one.

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Step 3 of 15 · Identity & Branding — 15 done

Identity Distro Branding

Distro Branding

Step 3 · Your name, logo, colors and artwork everywhere: system information, login, GRUB, boot splash and installer. DistroForge packs them into a <id>-branding package, so Debian updates keep them. Your changes wait in Review & Apply (step 14).

1. Identity and artwork

Your branding. Load from the ISO starts again from the extracted ISO.

Load from the ISO

Name: My Linux

ID (lower case): mylinux

Version: 1.0

Codename: Aurora

Home page: https://example.org

Support URL:

Bug report URL:

Maintainer: My Linux developers <mylinux@localhost>

Logo:

Back: 2. Repositories Done — next step: 4. Users

Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux

▶ Check the image

✓ Check the image finished

Branding package source written to /home/distroforge/mylinux/branding/mylinux-branding (8 diversions)

Copying 114 files of base-files

Ready Hide log

Identity & Branding

6. Step 4 · Users

The live user (default live, full name Live), with or without a password, automatic login, and more accounts in the image.

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Step 4 of 15 · Users — 15 done

Users and Passwords

Step 4 · The user of the live session (with a password, without one, or Debian's default) and accounts that every installed computer gets. Your changes wait in Review & Apply (step 14).

Live user

Created every time the ISO boots. Debian's default is the user 'user' with the password 'live'.

User name:live

Full name:Live

Password:Debian default password ('live')

new password

repeat the password

☒ Log in automatically when the ISO starts

Groups:audio cdrom dip floppy video plugdev netdev powerdev scanner bluetooth lpadmin

Live user: user — Debian default password ('live') (Debian defaults, not set yet)

Remove (back to Debian's user/live)

Save live user

Accounts in the image

Real accounts inside the system, for example an administrator account. They exist in the live session and on every computer installed from this ISO.

User	Full name	Password	Groups	Home
------	-----------	----------	--------	------

Back: 3. Identity & Branding

doneDone — next step: 5. Language

Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux

▶ Check the image

✓ Check the image finished

Branding package source written to /home/distroforge/mylinux/branding/mylinux-branding (8 diversions)

Copying 114 files of base-files

Ready

Hide log

Users

7. Step 5 · Language

Default language, keyboard layout, time zone (default Asia/Dili) and language packs. The language is also used by the installer and the boot menu.

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Step 5 of 15 · Language — 15 done

Language

Step 5 · Language, keyboard and time zone of the live system, the installer and installed computers, and more languages to choose from in the boot menu. Your changes wait in Review & Apply (step 14).

Default language

Language: English — English (United States) (en_US.UTF-8)

Time zone: Asia/Dili

Keyboard layout: us

Keyboard variant: optional, e.g. intl, dvorak, nodeadkeys

Tetun has no system locale yet: for Timor-Leste choose Português (pt_PT.UTF-8) or English and add the other one below.

More languages

Generated too, and offered at login and in the installer. Tick the languages for the boot menu as well.

☐ English — en_US.UTF-8

☐ English (UK) — en_GB.UTF-8

☒ Português — pt_PT.UTF-8

☐ Português (Brasil) — pt_BR.UTF-8

☒ Bahasa Indonesia — id_ID.UTF-8

☐ Bahasa Melayu — ms_MY.UTF-8

☐ Filipino — fil_PH.UTF-8

What to do

☒ Install translations and spell checking for installed programs (LibreOffice, Firefox, Thunderbird, hunspell, CJK fonts and input)

☒ Add a 'Language' submenu to the ISO boot menu (GRUB and ISOLINUX)

☒ Use as the default of the Calamares installer (language and time zone)

Apply language

Back: 4. Users

done Done — next step: 6. Desktop

Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux

▶ Check the image

✓ Check the image finished

Branding package source written to /home/distroforge/mylinux/branding/mylinux-branding (8 diversions)

Copying 114 files of base-files

Ready

Hide log

Language, keyboard and time zone

8. Step 6 · Desktop

Choose a desktop (GNOME, KDE Plasma, Xfce, Cinnamon, MATE, LXQt, Budgie, ...) and its edition under the names the desktop itself uses (minimal, standard, full with applications). Set the login screen and default session too.

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Step 6 of 15 · Desktop — 15 done

Desktop

Step 6 - Choose a desktop environment or window manager and how complete it is (Mini, Compact, Full, Full with apps), then the login screen, X11 or Wayland and the compositor. Your changes wait in Review & Apply (step 14).

Desktop environment or window manager

Eduka-Desktop ✓ Desktop

GNOME Desktop

KDE Plasma Desktop

Xfce Desktop

Cinnamon Desktop

MATE Desktop

LXQt ✓ Desktop

LXDE Desktop

Budgie Desktop

GNOME Flashback Desktop

Enlightenment Desktop

Openbox ✓ Window manager

i3 Window manager

Fluxbox Window manager

IceWM Window manager

awesome Window manager

JWM Window manager

herbstluftwm Window manager

bspwm Window manager

dwm Window manager

spectrwm Window manager

Sway (Wayland) Window manager

labwc (Wayland) Window manager

Wayfire (Wayland) Window manager

Hyprland (Wayland)

◀ Back: 5. Language

✓ done Done — next step: 7. Software ▶

Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux

▶ Check the image

✓ Check the image finished

Branding package source written to /home/distroforge/mylinux/branding/mylinux-branding (8 diversions)

Copying 114 files of base-files

Ready

Hide log

Desktops and editions

9. Step 7 · Software

Search, install and remove Debian packages; add Flathub applications by category; and replace the default applications (browser, mail, editor, terminal, ...) for all users.

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Step 7 of 15 · Software — 15 done

Packages

Flatpak apps

Replace apps

Packages and Applications

Step 7 - Every Debian package of the image: search, tick to add, untick to remove. You can also remove the applications that came with the ISO. Your changes wait in Review & Apply (step 14).

Maintenance

Refresh package lists

Upgrade all

Autoremove

Install .deb files...

Synaptic / terminal / live desktop...

All Debian packages

Ticked = installed in the ISO. Green: installed or to be installed; red: to be removed. 'Applications' hides libraries and other parts nobody starts from the menu.

officeApplicationsAll sections

Package	Version	Section	Size (KiB)	Description
☐ hyphen-as	0.9.0-2	text	21	Assamese hyphenation patterns for LibreOffice
☐ hyphen-bn	0.9.0-2	text	21	Bengali hyphenation patterns for LibreOffice
☐ hyphen-gu	0.9.0-2	text	21	Gujarati hyphenation patterns for LibreOffice
☐ hyphen-hi	0.9.0-2	text	21	Hindi hyphenation patterns for LibreOffice
☐ hyphen-kn	0.9.0-2	text	21	Kannada hyphenation patterns for LibreOffice
☐ hyphen-ml	0.9.0-2	text	22	Malayalam hyphenation patterns for LibreOffice
☐ hyphen-mr	0.9.0-2	text	21	Marathi hyphenation patterns for LibreOffice

Back: 6. DesktopdoneDone — next step: 8. Kernel & Boot

Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux

Check the image

Check the image finished

Branding package source written to /home/distroforge/mylinux/branding/mylinux-branding (8 diversions)

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Packages

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Step 7 of 15 · Software — 15 done

Packages

Flatpak apps

Replace apps

Replace default applications

Step 7 - Use another browser, mail program, office suite, editor, file manager, terminal or player. The new one becomes the default for every user; the old one can be removed. Your changes wait in Review & Apply (step 14).

Default applications of the image

Kind	Installed now	Default for its files
Archive manager	—	—
Calculator	—	—
E-mail	—	—
File manager	—	—
Image viewer	—	—
Music player	—	—

Reload

Replace

Pick the kind, then the program that should do the job. You can type any Debian package name too.

Kind: Web browser

Back: 6. DesktopdoneDone — next step: 8. Kernel & Boot

Check the image

Check the image finished

Branding package source written to /home/distroforge/mylinux/branding/mylinux-branding (8 diversions)

Copying 114 files of base-files

List Flatpak apps

List Flatpak apps finished

List Flatpak apps — finishedHide log

Replacing default applications

10. Step 8 · Kernel & Boot

Choose the kernel, install kernels from third-party repositories (temporary repositories are removed again by the build), edit the GRUB/ISOLINUX boot menu, choose a GRUB theme (checked first) and the boot loader of installed systems (GRUB, systemd-boot, rEFInd).

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Step 8 of 15 · Kernel & Boot — 15 done

Kernel

Boot Menu

GRUB Design

Kernel

Step 8 - The Linux kernel of your distribution: Debian kernels, backports or third-party kernels, firmware and drivers, and the GRUB settings of installed systems. Your changes wait in Review & Apply (step 14).

Installed kernels

Version	Package	Origin	Size	initrd	Headers	ISO	Held
6.12.38+deb13-amd64	-	copied by hand	0 MiB	yes			
6.12.43+deb13-amd64	-	copied by hand	0 MiB	yes		•	

No kernel metapackage: kernels are not updated automatically.

Remove

Hold / unhold

Update initramfs

Copy to the ISO now

Use for the ISO

Install a Debian kernel

Debian's kernels are signed for Secure Boot.

linux-image-amd64 (newest of the release, recommended)

Show all

Back: 7. Software

done

Done — next step: 9. Look & Feel

Check the image

Check the image finished

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List Flatpak apps finished

List Flatpak apps — finished

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Kernel

Boot Menu

GRUB Design

GRUB Design

Step 8 - A GRUB theme for the boot menu (checked first), the menu entries, and the boot loader the installer puts on computers. Your changes wait in Review & Apply (step 14).

GRUB theme

A theme folder or archive with theme.txt (for example from gnome-look.org or a theme's GitHub page). It is used by the GRUB menu of the ISO (UEFI) and, if you like, of installed systems. The BIOS menu of the ISO is ISOLINUX: it keeps its background (Boot Menu tab).

Drop a GRUB theme folder or archive (.zip, .tar.gz, .tar.xz) here

Add files...

Add folder...

Theme:

Also for installed systems (GRUB_THEME)

Remove theme

Use this theme

The ISO's own GRUB look is in use.

Menu designer

The entries of the ISO's GRUB menu: rename them (double-click), change the order, remove some or add ready-made ones; choose the default entry, the timeout and the colors. Saved like a manual edit, so every build keeps it.

Edukasaun OS Live (amd64)

Utilities

Back: 7. Software

done

Done — next step: 9. Look & Feel

Check the image

Check the image finished

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Copying 114 files of base-files

List Flatpak apps

List Flatpak apps finished

List Flatpak apps — finished

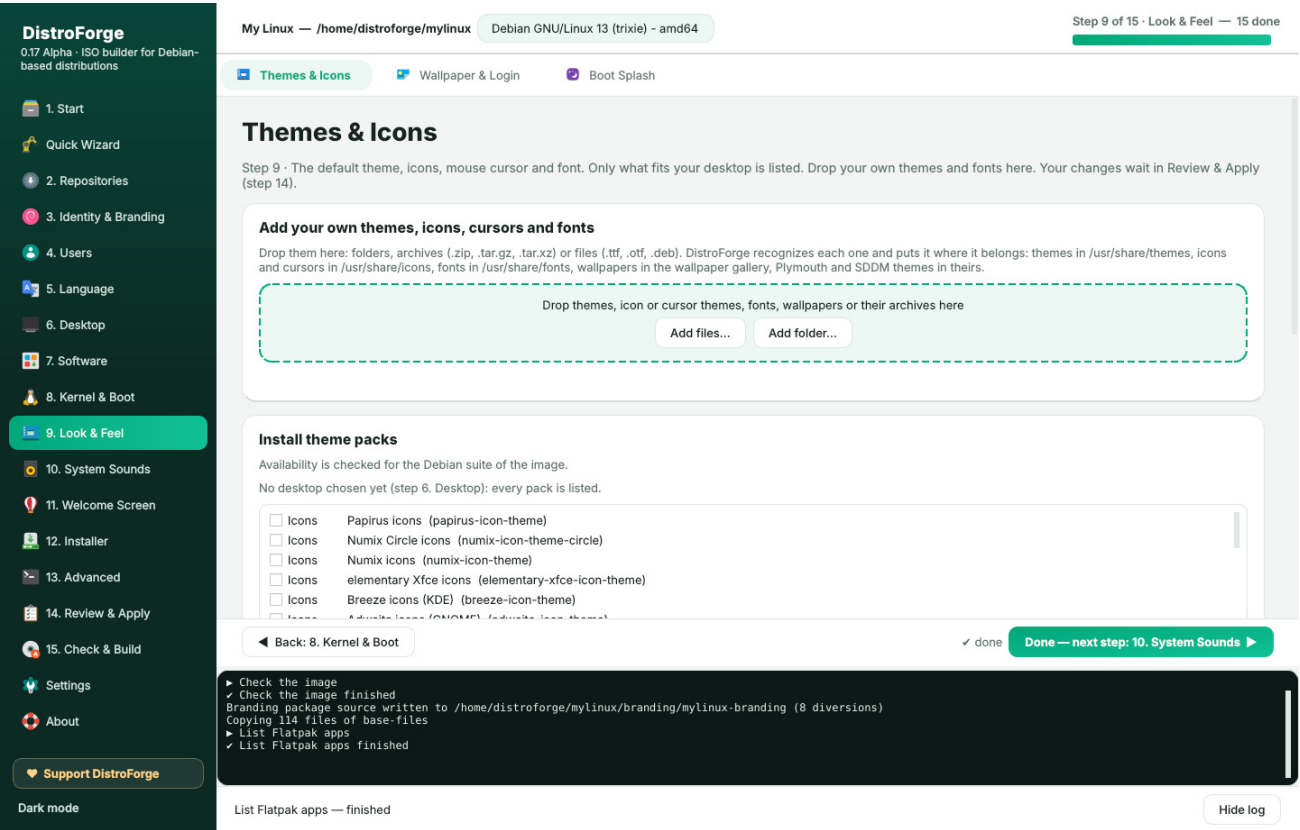
Hide log

GRUB Design

GRUB menu design

11. Step 9 · Look & Feel

GTK/Qt themes, icons, cursors and fonts that fit the chosen desktop, wallpapers, the login screen and the Plymouth boot splash.



Themes and icons

12. Steps 10 and 11 · Sounds & Welcome Screen

System sounds for boot, login, logout, shutdown, errors and notifications. A welcome screen with four pages shown after the first login.

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Step 10 of 15 · System Sounds — 15 done

System Sounds

Step 10 · Sounds for start-up, login, log out, shutdown, errors, notifications and devices. They become the default sounds of every desktop. Your changes wait in Review & Apply (step 14).

Sound theme

Your own theme inherits the freedesktop theme: events without a sound of yours keep the standard one.

Theme name:

Or use an installed theme: Use it

Drop sound files or a folder here (OGG, WAV, FLAC, MP3). Names such as boot.ogg, login.wav, shutdown.ogg, error.oga or notification.ogg are matched to their event automatically.

Add files... Add folder...

Sounds

Choose a sound for each event, play it here, or clear it.

System			
Boot (computer starts)	— standard sound —	Choose...	▶ Play Clear
Startup (user logs in)	— standard sound —	Choose...	▶ Play Clear
Log out	— standard sound —	Choose...	▶ Play Clear

◀ Back: 9. Look & Feel ✓ done Done — next step: 11. Welcome Screen ▶

▶ Check the image
✓ Check the image finished
Branding package source written to /home/distroforge/mylinux/branding/mylinux-branding (8 diversions)
Copying 114 files of base-files
▶ List Flatpak apps
✓ List Flatpak apps finished

List Flatpak apps — finished Hide log

System sounds

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0.17 Alpha - ISO builder for Debian-based distributions

1. Start

Quick Wizard

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3. Identity & Branding

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6. Desktop

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My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64

Step 11 of 15 · Welcome Screen — 15 done

Welcome Screen

Step 11 · Four pages users see after logging in: your logo, text, pictures and buttons to a website, a program or the installer. Your changes wait in Review & Apply (step 14).

Welcome screen

☒ Add the welcome screen to the image

Window title:

Logo: Browse...

Show:

Window size: x

Colors: Background Text Titles

Buttons Button text

Texts:

Pages

Design each page; the preview shows the page you are editing.

Page 1 Page 2 Page 3 Page 4

◀ Back: 10. System Sounds ✓ done Done — next step: 12. Installer ▶

▶ Check the image
✓ Check the image finished
Branding package source written to /home/distroforge/mylinux/branding/mylinux-branding (8 diversions)
Copying 114 files of base-files
▶ List Flatpak apps
✓ List Flatpak apps finished

List Flatpak apps — finished Hide log

Welcome screen

13. Step 12 · Installer

Set up the Calamares installer: modules, order, slides, default partitioning and texts. **Check the installer** finds mistakes before the build; the **How to fix** column says whether a problem is fixed automatically.

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Step 12 of 15 · Installer — 15 done

Result	File	Details	How to fix
✗ Problem	/etc/calamares/settings.conf	settings.conf...	Automatic: Install calamares
✗ Problem	/etc/calamares/settings.conf	branding ...	By hand
✗ Problem	/etc/calamares/settings.conf	the 'sequenc...	By hand

3 problem(s), 0 warning(s)

Fix automatically

Check the installer

Users and passwords

☐ Log in automatically (default of the checkbox)

☒ Ask for a root password

☒ Offer 'use the same password for root'

☐ Allow weak passwords

☐ 'Allow weak passwords' ticked by default

Password length: min max

User groups:

Administrator group:

Shell:

Live user

These are the rules for the accounts the installer creates. The user of the live session, its password (or no password) and accounts built into the image are set on the Users page.

Live user: user — Debian default password ('live')

Users and passwords...

Back: 11. Welcome Screen

done

Done — next step: 13. Advanced

Check the image

Check the image finished

Branding package source written to /home/distroforge/mylinux/branding/mylinux-branding (8 diversions)

Copying 114 files of base-files

List Flatpak apps

List Flatpak apps finished

List Flatpak apps — finished

Hide log

Installer check

14. Step 13 · Advanced

A terminal inside the image, the live session in a window (Xephyr), hook scripts, JSON recipes and the package workshop to change files of installed Debian packages.

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My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64

Step 13 of 15 · Advanced — 15 done

Terminal & Live Package Workshop

Terminal & Live

Step 13 - For experts: start the system's desktop in a window and change things by hand, use a root terminal, or run scripts. Everything ends up in the ISO.

Live edit session

Runs the image's desktop in a nested window (Xephyr). In the default mode your changes become the defaults of every new user (/etc/skel).

Session: Edukasaun Desktop

Window size: 1280x800

Mode: Save as default for all users (/etc/skel)

Status: Not running

Start live session **Stop** **Run in session**

Settings app **Open in session** **Stop and build ISO**

Install applications

Three ways, all installing straight into the image: type package names, use the Synaptic package manager in a window, or work in a root terminal.

Install with APT

Done — next step: 14. Review & Apply

► Check the image
✓ Check the image finished
Branding package source written to /home/distroforge/mylinux/branding/mylinux-branding (8 diversions)
Copying 114 files of base-files
► List Flatpak apps
✓ List Flatpak apps finished

List Flatpak apps — finished

Dark mode

Terminal and live session

15. Step 14 · Review & Apply

Changes from steps 2 to 13 **do not** change the image right away. They all wait in the Review & Apply list. The green button at the top shows how many are waiting.

- Tick every change you are sure about.
- **Go back and change it** opens the step of that change.
- **Remove from the list** drops a change; **Up/Down** change the order.
- **Apply all changes** is enabled when everything is ticked. If one change fails, the ones applied before it leave the list and the rest keep waiting.

Experts can apply every change at once (Settings → Apply every change at once).

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My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64

Step 14 of 15 · Review & Apply — 15 done **Review & Apply: 5 waiting**

Review & Apply

Step 14 - Everything you chose waits here. Tick each change when you are sure, or go back and change it. Then apply them all at once.

Changes waiting to be applied

- ☒ 1. Install the Xfce desktop (full with applications) — Desktop
- ☒ 2. Install 3 package(s) — Software
- ☐ 3. Apply the system sound theme — System Sounds
- ☐ 4. Install the welcome screen — Welcome Screen
- ☐ 5. Apply the GRUB theme — Kernel & Boot

2 of 5 change(s) checked — tick every change you are sure about to apply them

[Tick all](#) [Go back and change it](#) [Remove from the list](#) [Up](#) [Down](#) [Apply all changes](#)

Changes run in this order. A failed change stops the rest; nothing is lost.

Your distribution so far
Name: My Linux 1.0

[Back: 13. Advanced](#) [Done — next step: 15. Check & Build](#)

✓ List Flatpak apps finished
Waiting in Review & Apply: Install the Xfce desktop (full with applications)
Waiting in Review & Apply: Install 3 package(s)
Waiting in Review & Apply: Apply the system sound theme
Waiting in Review & Apply: Install the welcome screen
Waiting in Review & Apply: Apply the GRUB theme

Added to Review & Apply: Apply the GRUB theme (5 waiting) [Hide log](#)

Review & Apply

16. Step 15 · Check & Build

Check now finds what would make the build fail, the ISO not boot, or private data leak into it. Every row says how to fix it:

- **Automatic:** ... — press **Fix automatically**; DistroForge fixes it and checks again.
- **By hand (double-click)** — double-click the row to open the right step.

When you press **Build ISO image** with problems left, DistroForge asks: **Fix automatically, I will fix it myself** or **Build anyway**.

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Step 15 of 15 · Check & Build — 15 done

Check & Build

Last step · Check the image, choose the ISO size, build the ISO (BIOS and UEFI, ready for USB sticks) and try it in a virtual machine.

Check before building
Finds what would make the build fail, the ISO not boot, or private data leak into it.

Result	Check	Details	How to fix
✗ Problem	Installer	/etc/calamares/settings.conf: settings.conf is there but the ...	Automatic: Install calamares
✗ Problem	Installer	/etc/calamares/settings.conf: branding 'debian' has no folder wit...	By hand (double-click)
✗ Problem	Installer	/etc/calamares/settings.conf: the 'sequence' is empty	By hand (double-click)
✓ OK	Distribution	Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64	
✓ OK	Build tools on this computer	mksquashfs and xorriso found	
✓ OK	Package database	every package is fully installed	
✓ OK	Kernel	6.12.43+deb13-amd64 with its initrd (2 kernels)	

3 problem(s), 2 warning(s) — fix the problems before building

Deep check (apt-get check)

Fix automatically

Check now

ISO size
Choose how big the ISO may be. Compression is lossless: every file comes back exactly as it was, so a smaller ISO is never a damaged ISO — it only takes longer to build.

Target size:

No limit (fastest build)

Estimate

Back: 14. Review & Apply

done

► Check the image
✓ Check the image finished
Branding package source written to /home/distroforge/mylinux/branding/mylinux-branding (8 diversions)
Copying 114 files of base-files
► List Flatpak apps
✓ List Flatpak apps finished

List Flatpak apps — finished

Hide log

Check & Build

17. ISO size

Choose a target size: as small as possible, 100 MB, 300 MB, 500 MB, 700 MB (CD), 1 GB, 2 GB, 4.4 GB (DVD) or no limit. **Estimate** compresses a sample of the system and computes the size of every method.

Squashfs compression is **lossless**: every file comes back exactly as it was. A smaller ISO is never a damaged ISO, it only takes longer to build (xz is smallest and slowest, lz4 fastest).

When the target is too small, DistroForge suggests safe size savers: documentation, manual pages, unused translations, APT lists and old kernels. License files always stay. Removing applications you do not need helps most.

The screenshot shows the DistroForge ISO builder interface. On the left is a sidebar with 15 steps: 1. Start, 2. Repositories, 3. Identity & Branding, 4. Users, 5. Language, 6. Desktop, 7. Software, 8. Kernel & Boot, 9. Look & Feel, 10. System Sounds, 11. Welcome Screen, 12. Installer, 13. Advanced, 14. Review & Apply, 15. Check & Build (highlighted in green). Below the sidebar are links for Settings, About, and a Support DistroForge button. The main area is titled 'My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64'. It shows 'Step 15 of 15 · Check & Build — 15 done'. The 'image' section has fields for File name (template: {id}-{version}-{suite}-{arch}-{date}.iso, example: mylinux-1.0-stable-amd64-20261008.iso), Volume label (MYLINUX_1.0), Compression (zstd - fast, good (recommended) Level 15), Boot loader (Automatic), and Initramfs (Rebuild when needed). There are checkboxes for Secure Boot, Remove Debian-Installer entries, Reuse existing filesystem.squashfs, and Also write SHA-512 and MD5 checksums. The 'Clean-up before compressing' section has checkboxes for Clean APT package cache, Empty log files, Reset machine-id, Remove saved network connections, Remove old kernels, Remove Flatpak download caches, Remove APT package lists, Remove shell history and root's caches, Remove SSH host keys, Empty /tmp and /var/tmp, Remove caches from /etc/skel, and Smaller ISO: remove documentation. A 'Back: 14. Review & Apply' button is at the bottom left of this section. A 'done' button is at the bottom right. A log window at the bottom shows: 'Check the image', 'Check the image finished', 'Branding package source written to /home/distroforge/mylinux/branding/mylinux-branding (8 diversions)', 'Copying 114 files of base-files', 'List Flatpak apps', 'List Flatpak apps finished'. A 'List Flatpak apps — finished' message is at the bottom left of the log window, and a 'Hide log' button is at the bottom right.

Target size and build options

18. Testing and writing to USB

After the build, **Boot ISO** in the **Test in a virtual machine** card boots the ISO with QEMU (BIOS or UEFI). The ISO is hybrid: write it to a USB stick with GNOME Disks, balenaEtcher, Ventoy or:

```
sudo dd if=mylinux.iso of=/dev/sdX bs=4M status=progress oflag=sync
```

Replace /dev/sdX with the right USB device; everything on it is erased.

19. Command line

Every step is also available in a terminal, in the order of the work:

```
sudo distroforge new --iso debian-live.iso ~/mylinux
cd ~/mylinux
sudo distroforge brand identity name="My Linux" version=1.0
sudo distroforge apt install vlc gimp
sudo distroforge check --fix
sudo distroforge build --target-size 700
sudo distroforge test
```

`distroforge --help` lists the commands by step; `distroforge COMMAND --help` explains one command.

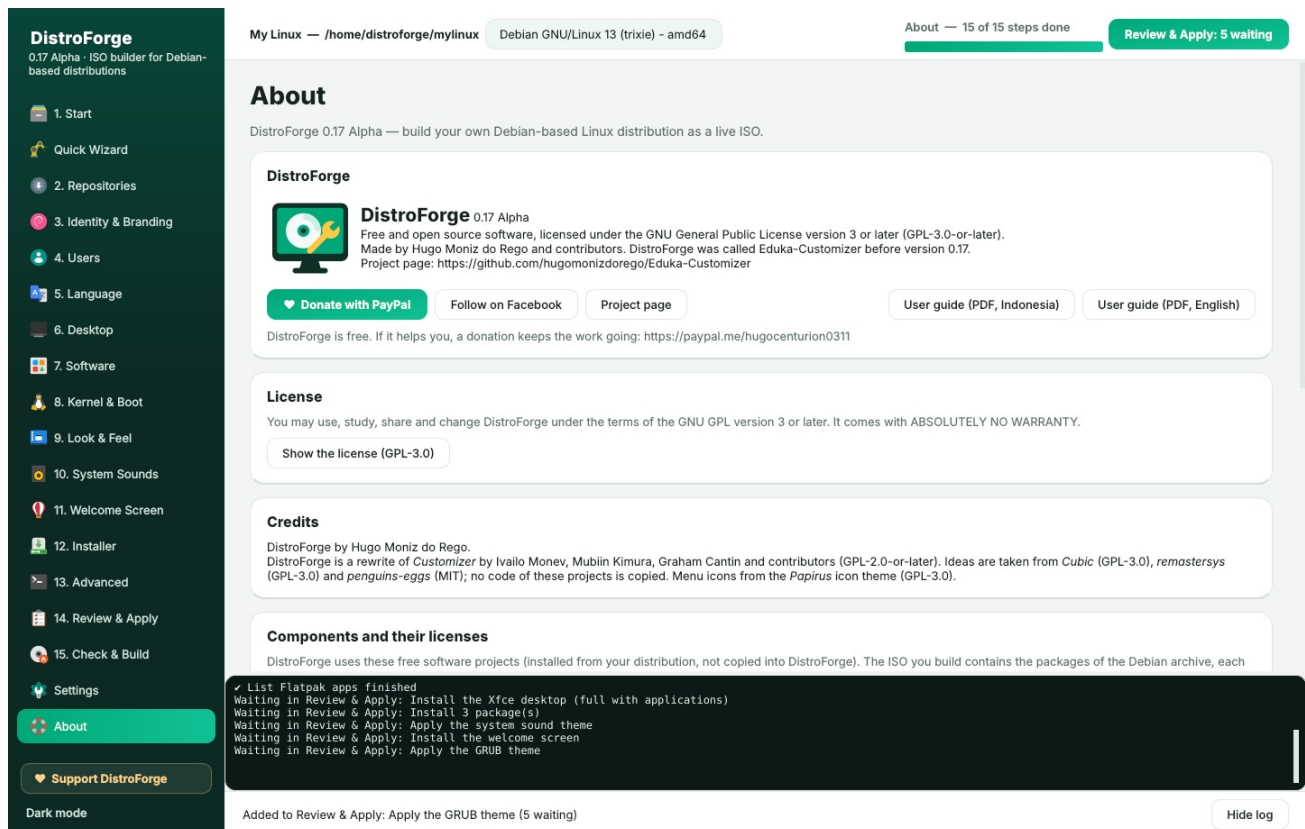
20. Common problems

- **'grub needs /usr/sbin/grub-install in the image'** — since 0.17 no longer reported for live ISOs that install GRUB from the ISO pool during installation. If it shows, press Fix automatically (installs grub-efi/grub-pc-bin).
- **Half-installed packages** — Fix automatically runs `dpkg --configure -a` and `apt-get -f install`.
- **Not enough disk space** — remove caches with `sudo distroforge clean` or move the project folder to another disk.
- **No internet** — installing packages and Flatpaks needs internet; all other edits work offline.
- **Log** — every message is in the log panel and in `/tmp/distroforge/distroforge.log`.

21. License, trademarks and support

DistroForge is free software under the GNU General Public License version 3 or later, WITHOUT ANY WARRANTY. The license of every component (Python, Qt, squashfs-tools, xorriso, GRUB, Calamares, live-boot, Papirus, ...) is listed on the **About** page. The packages in your ISO each keep their own license (/usr/share/doc/PACKAGE/copyright).

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DistroForge
0.17 Alpha - ISO builder for Debian-based distributions

My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64 About — 15 of 15 steps done Review & Apply: 5 waiting

About

DistroForge 0.17 Alpha — build your own Debian-based Linux distribution as a live ISO.

DistroForge
DistroForge 0.17 Alpha
Free and open source software, licensed under the GNU General Public License version 3 or later (GPL-3.0-or-later).
Made by Hugo Moniz do Rego and contributors. DistroForge was called Eduka-Customizer before version 0.17.
Project page: <https://github.com/hugomonizdorego/Eduka-Customizer>

Donate with PayPal Follow on Facebook Project page User guide (PDF, Indonesia) User guide (PDF, English)

DistroForge is free. If it helps you, a donation keeps the work going: <https://paypal.me/hugocenturion0311>

License

You may use, study, share and change DistroForge under the terms of the GNU GPL version 3 or later. It comes with ABSOLUTELY NO WARRANTY.

Show the license (GPL-3.0)

Credits

DistroForge by Hugo Moniz do Rego.
DistroForge is a rewrite of Customizer by Ivallo Monev, Mublin Kimura, Graham Cantin and contributors (GPL-2.0-or-later). Ideas are taken from Cubic (GPL-3.0), remastersys (GPL-3.0) and penguins-eggs (MIT); no code of these projects is copied. Menu icons from the Papirus icon theme (GPL-3.0).

Components and their licenses

DistroForge uses these free software projects (installed from your distribution, not copied into DistroForge). The ISO you build contains the packages of the Debian archive, each

```
✓ List Flatpak apps finished
Waiting in Review & Apply: Install the Xfce desktop (full with applications)
Waiting in Review & Apply: Install 3 package(s)
Waiting in Review & Apply: Apply the system sound theme
Waiting in Review & Apply: Install the welcome screen
Waiting in Review & Apply: Apply the GRUB theme
```

Added to Review & Apply: Apply the GRUB theme (5 waiting) Hide log

The About page

Made by Hugo Moniz do Rego. If DistroForge helps you, a donation keeps the project going:

- PayPal: <https://paypal.me/hugocenturion0311>
- Facebook: <https://facebook.com/hugomonizdorego>
- Project: <https://github.com/hugomonizdorego/Eduka-Customizer>